

When people with lower back pain try to relax their back, what actually happens: an informal Feldy reader poll, May–June 2026

Chava Sorani, GCFP · Feldy — online Feldenkrais Method® gentle-movement program · feldy.me · Data brief published 23 June 2026 · Dataset DOI: [10.5281/zenodo.20800490](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20800490)

ABSTRACT

In an on-site reader poll of 88 visitors to feldy.me who arrived looking for help with lower back pain (May–June 2026), only 18 percent reported that their back actually relaxed when they tried to relax it; 82 percent described it as held, undifferentiated, or unclear. 86 percent reported waking with stiffness or aches. 76 percent had tried heat, ice, or rest; 62 percent pills or topical creams; only 4 percent had tried the Feldenkrais Method. This is a small, self-selected sample and is descriptive only. The figures suggest a population whose presenting picture is consistent with held muscular tone and reduced interoceptive resolution, a pattern the Feldenkrais Method is designed to address. The accompanying article is at feldy.me/blog/why-your-back-wont-relax.

METHODS

An informal quiz was embedded in the Feldy website and shown to visitors who arrived through queries related to lower back pain between May and June 2026. Two main multiple-choice questions were asked: (i) what happens when the respondent tries to relax their back (single-choice, $n = 51$), and (ii) what treatments they had already tried for their back (multi-select, $n = 45$). Three single-question summary prompts asked about stiffness on waking, the experience of the back letting go, and body affect (partial samples between 39 and 57). Total respondents across the quiz: 88 people. Responses are anonymous; no personally identifying information was collected. The sample is self-selected and unscreened; figures are descriptive only and no inferential statistics are reported. The full dataset (CSV) and methodology are deposited at Zenodo (Sorani, 2026).

RESULTS

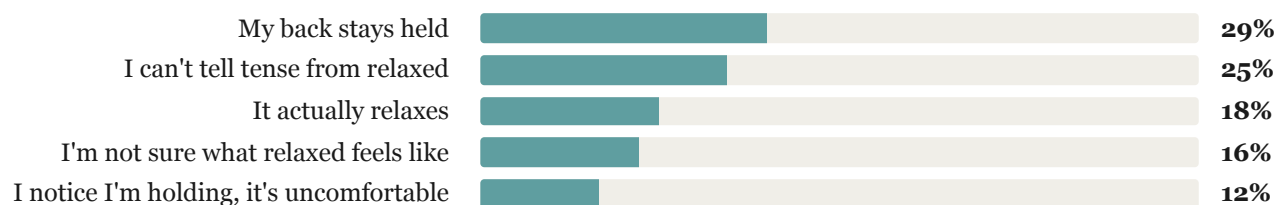


Figure 1. When you try to relax your back, what happens? (single-choice, $n = 51$)

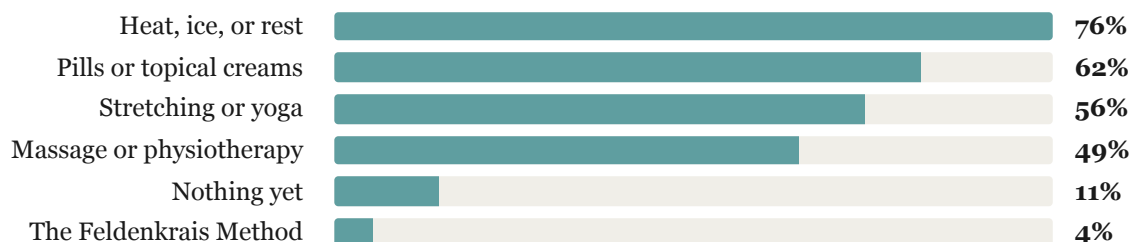


Figure 2. What treatments have you tried for your back? (multi-select; multiple answers allowed; $n = 45$)

Three additional single-question prompts produced the following summary responses:

- Wake up with stiffness or aches: **86 percent yes**
- Back fully lets go when you try to relax it: **82 percent no**
- How do you feel about your body right now: **74 percent frustrated or apprehensive**

DISCUSSION

The most striking pattern in the data is the gap between the conventional reading of "relaxed" and what respondents in this sample actually report. Only 18 percent describe a clean relaxation response. 54 percent describe their back as either staying held or being indistinguishable from a tense state, and a further 16 percent are unsure what relaxed even feels like. Read alongside the treatment history in Figure 2, in which the most common interventions are passive (heat, ice, rest) or pharmacological, this is consistent with the picture the Feldenkrais Method is designed to address: a body in which muscular tone is held by the nervous system as a learned pattern, and in which the proprioceptive signal back from the affected region has reduced resolution.

The data should be read with three important caveats. The sample is small ($n = 88$ total; per-question n between 39 and 57), self-selected (visitors to a Feldenkrais-focused website), and unscreened (no demographic or clinical filter). No inferential statistics are reported and the figures are not generalisable beyond the group that took the quiz. Useful next-step questions for a larger study would include the relationship between scores on Figure 1 and clinically measured pain duration, and whether the 96 percent of respondents who had not tried somatic movement education reflects a population-level access gap or a self-selection artefact of the recruitment surface.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The full dataset, methodology, and per-question wording are deposited at Zenodo under CCo: Sorani, C. (2026). *Feldy reader poll: when people with lower back pain try to relax their back (May–June 2026)*. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20800490>

REFERENCES

1. Sorani, C. (2026). *Why your back won't relax*. Feldy Blog. <https://feldy.me/blog/why-your-back-wont-relax>
2. Sorani, C. (2026). *Feldy reader poll: when people with lower back pain try to relax their back (May–June 2026)* [Data set]. Zenodo. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20800490>
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This is an informal reader poll, not a clinical study. It is published as a small open dataset and a descriptive data brief, to give other practitioners and researchers a snapshot of what visitors to a Feldenkrais-focused website report about their own back-relaxation experience. Correspondence: editorial@feldy.me · feldy.me.